

Test Layer 1: Economy Fix

Feedback form (fill out after the game): [layer-1-feedback.pdf](#)

Based on the baseline rules. Only the Resource Economy section is changed. Everything else is identical.

What we're testing: Does a faster Rune economy fix the dead opening and shorten the game?

Hypothesis: With more Runes earlier, skills come online from Turn 1. The first rounds of pure positioning are eliminated. Game should be shorter and more action-dense.

Watch for:

- Do players use skills in Rounds 1–3?
- Is the game shorter? (Target: under 25 rounds)
- Do cheap skills (2-cost) feel spamable?
- Is hoarding a problem?
- Do expensive skills (4-cost) feel reachable at a reasonable time?

Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

Draw conditions:

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

Components

Per player: 1 King · 5 Champions · 6 Guards

Shared: 10×10 grid board (no terrain effects) · Skill tokens or cards · Rune tokens · Round tracker

Setup

1. **Board:** Use the 10×10 grid. Ignore any terrain markings.
2. **First player:** Flip a coin.
3. **Piece placement:** Each player places pieces on their own back two rows:
 - Back row (row 1/10): King in the centre, Champions fill the remaining 5 spaces.
 - Second row (row 2/9): All 6 Guards.
4. **Skill Draft:** Alternating picks. P1 picks 2 skills for one Champion, then P2. Repeat until all Champions and the King have 2 skills each (12 per player). Duplicates allowed.
5. **Starting Runes:** Each player starts with **6 Runes**. (*Changed from baseline 4.*)
6. P1 begins Round 1.

Round Structure

A **Round** = P1's Turn + P2's Turn.

At the **start of each player's turn** (before they do anything), that player collects their Rune income. (*Exception: Round 1 — players begin with their starting Runes and collect nothing before their first turn.*)

Turn Structure

Each **Turn** has two phases, in order:

1. **Movement Phase** — spend Move Slots to move pieces (and attack).
2. **Action Phase** — spend Skill Slots to activate skills.

You may use 0 slots in either phase.

Movement Phase

You have **2 Move Slots** per turn. Spend 1 Move Slot to move one piece.

Piece	Normal speed	Injured speed
Guard	2 tiles	1 tile
Champion / King	1 tile	1 tile

Free pathing: A piece may move in any direction — horizontal, vertical, diagonal — taking any route up to its speed in tiles. The route does not have to be a straight line.

Pieces block movement: A moving piece cannot pass through any other piece, ally or opponent. It must stop when its path is blocked.

- *Exception:* With free pathing, a piece may go around a blocking piece if total tiles moved stays within speed (e.g. a Guard using 2 diagonal moves to go around a piece directly in the way).

You may move the same piece with both Move Slots, or move two different pieces.

Standard Attack

To attack, spend a Move Slot to move your piece **onto a tile occupied by an enemy piece**.

- Deal **2 DMG** to the enemy.
- **If the enemy is removed:** your piece occupies the tile.
- **If the enemy survives** (Armor absorbed the damage): your piece stops on the tile immediately before the target.

You may attack with one Move Slot and move a different piece with the other Move Slot in the same turn.

Action Phase

You have **2 Skill Slots** per turn (to start — see Progression).

Spend 1 Skill Slot to activate one equipped skill on one of your Champions or King:

1. Announce the skill and the target.
2. Pay the skill's Rune cost.
3. Apply the skill's effect.

The same Champion can activate multiple skills in one turn if you have Skill Slots remaining.

Skill System

Skill Path: Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

Blocking: The Skill Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

Range: The distance in tiles along the Skill Path from caster to target.

All skills cost 1 Skill Slot unless noted otherwise.

CHANGED: Resource Economy

	Baseline	Layer 1
Starting Runes	4	6
Rune income (from Round 2)	+1 / turn	+2 / turn
Income scaling	+1 every 7 rounds	+1 every 5 rounds

Rune income is collected at the **start of each player's own turn** (not Round 1).

Round	Income per player turn
1	0 (start with 6)
2–5	+2

Round	Income per player turn
6–10	+3
11+	+4

No Rune cap.

Health & Armor

All pieces have 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed.

State	HP	Effect
Normal	2	No penalty
Injured	1	Speed capped at 1. Skill Range –1.
Removed	0	Piece leaves the board permanently.

Damage:

- 1 DMG to Normal → Injured.
- 1 DMG to Injured → Removed.
- 2 DMG to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

Armor:

- Pieces can hold up to 3 Armor points (granted by skills).
- Each Armor point absorbs **1 DMG instance**, then is destroyed.
- Armor is resolved **before** HP damage.
- Armor does not prevent Injured status.

Bodyguard Rule

When you make a **Standard Attack** against an opponent's Champion or King, the defender may intercept — **if** a friendly Guard is adjacent to **both the tile immediately before the target (along the attack path) and the defending piece**.

Interception:

1. Defender announces a Guard to intercept.
2. The Guard is removed instead of the original target.
3. The attacker **does not move**.

Only Standard Attacks can be intercepted. Skills always hit directly. Interception is optional.

Skill Drafting

1. Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
2. Alternating draft: P1 assigns 2 skills to one Champion → P2 assigns 2 skills to one Champion → repeat.
3. Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
4. Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

Skill Reference

Cat.	Name	Cost	Effect
Strike	Lance Thrust	2	Target within range takes 1 DMG
Strike	Hook Pull	3	Target takes 1 DMG, pulled 1 tile toward caster along Skill Path
Strike	Armor Breaker	2	Remove 1 Armor from target
Strike	Rune Theft	3	Target takes 1 DMG. Steal 1 Rune from opponent.
Strike	Blade Tempest	4	Target takes 1 DMG. Adjacent pieces pushed 1 tile away from target.
Shield	Rust Shield	2	Self: gain +1 Armor
Shield	Field Medic	3	Heal 1 HP on an adjacent ally (cannot exceed starting HP)
Shield	Armorsmith	3	Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor
Move	Quick Dash	3	Self: move up to 2 tiles along Skill Path
Move	Air Blast	2	Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster
Move	Precision Thrust	3	Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses)
Move	Shadow Shift	4	Swap position with an allied piece. Range 3. Requires unobstructed Skill Path.
Move	Retreat Plan	4	Self: move along Skill Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards (range = Skill Range + 1)
Mystic	Focus Strike	1	Your next skill this turn gains +1 Range
Mystic	Blade Call	2	Your next skill this turn: pay +1 Rune to deal +1 DMG

Progression

Round	Skill Slots per turn
1–9	2
10–19	3
20+	4

Quick Reference

Concept	Rule
Movement	Free pathing, ≤ speed in tiles, cannot pass through pieces
Attack	Move onto enemy tile (1 Move Slot). 2 DMG.
Attack — target survives	Attacker stops on tile before target
Skill Path	Straight line (Queen). Blocked by all pieces.
Bodyguard	Guard adjacent to both attacker and defender. Standard Attacks only.
Rune income	Start of YOUR turn (not Round 1)
Healing	No cap. Same piece can be healed multiple times per turn.
Armor	Armor absorbs damage first, then HP